

FORT HISTORICAL MUSEUM SOCIETY

HERITAGE

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Honoring SPECIAL OPERATIONS COMMUNICATORS

by John Wilcox



At the Headquarters of the United States Special Operations Command (USSOCOM), the Commando Hall of Honor recognizes those Special Operators who have served with great distinction and have demonstrated leadership and selfless service within the SOF community. With less than 100 inductees, the members of the Commando Hall of Honor truly are the best of the best. Most people think of Special Operations as Direct Action (DA) missions like raids, airfield seizures, or hostage rescue. The more nuanced think of Unconventional Warfare (UW), Foreign Internal Defense (FID), or Special Reconnaissance (SR), but none of these Special Operations would be possible without exceptional communications and the communicators who make it all work. Included in the Commando Hall of Honor are two such communicators: Chief Warrant Officer Four (Ret.) Paul A. Zeisman and Master Sergeant (Ret.) Michael A. Pelaez. With 88 years of uniformed and civilian service between them, Mr Zeisman & Mr Pelaez have shaped Special Operations communications and by extension Department of Defense

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Chairman's Corner



Team - In this edition we dedicate our magazine to those communicators that supported our special operations community. These incredible young men and women have

often led the technological developments for our Army through the unique requirements to ensure their special operators could rapidly move, shoot, communicate and strike anywhere in the world. The stories of these accomplishments begin to end some of the mystique that surrounds our special operations community and will give you some great insights into the brave men and women who solved the wicked problem sets that truly enabled these special team of warriors. I hope you will enjoy reading the stories, seeing the pictures and reliving just some of the history that this edition will bring to light. I challenge you to join us in inspiring the next generation to service above self as we unlock and share the history of accomplishments that have occurred throughout our signal and cyber mission forces. Many thanks to our General Officers, Senior Executives and Sergeants Major who, along with each of you, continue to support the Historical Museum Society.

You can join our team by making a donation, contributing a story, picture or volunteering to help us share these stories.

In that spirit I am including the picture below that was taken back in 1994 when I was a Company Commander of an Airborne Signal Company at Fort Bragg that supported the XVIII Airborne Corps Main Command Post. As we were preparing to

conduct an airborne operation on green ramp I got a call that the Corps Commander would be joining us for this mission. Upon meeting General Shelton, he asked about our operation and immediately put me at ease with his confident calm demeanor. General Shelton is a legend and having come out of our special operations community I was nervous that our preparation would not meet his high standards. As I briefed him on our airborne assault and follow-on mission, I could see that he was pleased with our

planning, attention to detail and scope of the mission. I was amazed that this senior leader would take the time to come down inspect our training and to jump with us. His leadership by example is something I would never forget. General Shelton would go on to become the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff and I never forgot his leadership example and I was honored to support and serve alongside him at Fort Bragg. His outstanding example of leadership is emblematic of how our special operations community "lead from the

front." Many thanks to all of our special operator communicators and leaders for all you do as you truly are amongst our most elite warriors.



General Shelton and the young Captain Chase



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Laurin Groover

With over 25 years of extensive experience at the nexus of government, politics, and industry - including over a decade on Capitol Hill as senior staff to Armed Services Committee leaders - Laurin is an accomplished national security professional specializing in business and government relations strategies that advance the fielding of critical technologies to the warfighter. Co-Founder and President Women in Defense Augusta Chapter, member of the South Carolina Bar and the Honorable Order of Kentucky Colonels, recipient of the Palmetto Patriot Award, and former Chairman South Carolina Presidential Inaugural Ball Committee. She is a graduate of the University of the South (Sewanee) and the University of South Carolina School of Law.

Q & A *with* Brigadier General Jeth Rey



1. Tell us about your upbringing. Where were you born and raised and what was it like for you?

I was born on a small island of Anguilla, in the British West Indies. At three months, my mother moved to Saint

Thomas, U.S. Virgin Islands. We were pretty poor: it was not extravagant. My mom was a single parent. I was youngest of eight kids. My mother taught me a lot growing up that helped me throughout my years. She really trusted me as a young kid of seven or eight years old. She used to let me go to the grocery store and go to the bank to cash her check. So I learned responsibility and financial responsibility. It taught me discipline, responsibility, organization, maturity, and focus: traits I have carried with me throughout my life.

My first time in the US was at 13 yrs old when I moved to Virginia to visit my sister. From there, I attended junior high school and high school. I transferred because I wanted to get into an environment that was a little bit more conducive to learning.

2. What prompted you to join the army?

In high school, I joined the Navy JROTC. Truly, the main reason I joined was because I needed extra clothes to wear to school and more

importantly a jacket to stay warm. They issued us pea coats with our uniform and I needed a coat to keep me warm because typically I walked to school. I



prospered in JROTC and eventually I made it from a young cadet to the commander of our program.

I joined the Army right out of high school at 17 yrs old. We couldn't afford college and plus my grades weren't as great as they should've been in order for me to get a scholarship. Since I thrived in Navy JROTC, I went to the Navy recruiter and wanted to leave that day but they couldn't get me out of the door quickly enough. I went to the USMC recruiter and again they really couldn't get me out the door quick enough. I went to the Army and the Army was ready to go. So the next morning I left for Basic training at Ft. Dix, New Jersey.

3. Why Signal Regiment?



My recruiter told me that Signal would be a great choice. In 1983, Signal was more analog so I became a signaleer within the analog environment. My first duty assignment was in Korea. I was a tactical signal operator, laying wire, retrans systems, and operating the radio. My platoon Sergeant encouraged me to become an Airborne Soldier; so I submitted my 4187 and was selected to attend Airborne school. Subsequently, I was assigned to the 4th Psychological Operations Group (SO) (A). This was my introduction into Special Operations in 1985. I would spend the next 24 years assigned to numerous Special Operations units.

4. What impact did you see Signal make when you were a younger Soldier and why did you reenlist?

I saw Signal evolving from an analog environment to a more digital environment, and today in IP space. I had the advantage of being assigned within Special Operations and seeing how rapidly communication

Cont. next Page

technology advanced. Therefore, I really wanted to stay longer. When 112th Signal Battalion (SO) (A) was established in 1986 at Fort Bragg, I was one of the first five personnel assigned to the newly established organization. This new organization had special kit, the SOCA (Special Operations Communications Assemblage). It was mobile and being a Special Operations communicator was exciting as we developed new Spec Ops kits. I was really honored to be a plank holder and honored to go on a command 112th Signal Battalion (SO)(A) in 2012.

When I was an NCO, the 75th Ranger Regt needed communicators. My name was drawn from the pool of other communicators around the Army and we all got assigned to the 3rd Ranger Bn at Fort Benning Georgia. I spent the next 7 yrs in 3rd Ranger Bn as an NCO, Warrant, and Officer. I suspect this is the only time someone has served in all three of those capacities (NCO, Warrant, and Officer) in the Ranger Regiment.

5. Why did you become a warrant officer?



When I enlisted in the Army, my goal was to make it to SFC/E-7. I pinned on SFC in 8 yrs. I was intrigued about Warrant Officers. In the Special Operations community, I had been exposed to several credentialing courses that forced me to technically improve my level of expertise. Those opportunities propelled my career; thus I submitted my packet for a chance to attend warrant officer field. I was selected on my first look and upon graduation from the Warrant Basic Course I was reassigned to the 3rd Ranger BN.

6. Why did you become a commissioned officer?

As a CW2 while at the 3rd BN of 75th Ranger Regt, GEN Stephen Townsend (currently AFRICOM Commander) was a MAJ at the time, pushed me to become a commissioned officer and go to OCS. I was selected and So it was really because of GEN Townsend and LTG (Ret.) Frank Kearney (who was my BC and a LTC at the



time). Towards the end of OCS, then LTC Kearney needed a signal officer in his battalion in order to regain Readiness. So the day I graduated OCS as the DHG, I returned to 3rd Ranger BN as the SIGO, before I even when to Signal OBC. I went to OBC 4 months later.

7. How important is mentoring? Having a good mentor is key. Throughout my career I've benefitted from the candor, wisdom, and expertise from talented mentors. It was vital to have mentors who were not only the same level and/or rank, but sometimes noncommissioned officers who guided me. Solid mentoring ensures the mentee benefits from the mentor's key lessons learned and experiences that you have had over time. Mentoring is building that professional relationship and providing advice, encouragement, and impartial, direct, and timely feedback. A good mentor is a good listener, a good teacher, and one with impeccable character. My mentors in Special Operations encouraged me to progress from NCO, to Warrant, and now to General officer.

8. How do you stay technically proficient throughout the ranks?

I love my craft. In my early years as a younger soldier, I used to come home from work in the evening and just research and read technical manuals. I enjoyed drawing schematics. Also I perused websites and reviews to stay proficient. It is important to continue to study organizations like Google, Microsoft, CISCO and those power houses. It is important to understand their five-year and ten-year plans to help predict what's important in the tech world. Special Operations also emphasized the value of learning from those around you regardless of rank. This has helped me remain proficient throughout my career.

9. What is the future of signal how did your history in the Army get you ready for your current position?

I've been in the Army for 37 years and of which 24 years I was assigned within Special Operations. The

FIRESIDE CHAT: INGENUITY



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The following is an excerpt from Board Member Rick Piña's chat with Lt. General (LTG) John Morrison, Army Deputy G6. (The excerpt has been lightly edited for clarity.)

Rick Piña: You commanded the Joint Communication Service Element (JCSE). You've had amazing opportunities to deploy all over the planet with gear, and in unique missions. Can you think of a couple of examples of ingenuity? Where you never thought that this is what you were going to do with the gear and then all of a sudden, now here you are doing something that even the makers of the gear never expected?

LTG Morrison: I can think of a couple. I'll give one Army and one Navy example, since you brought up the Joint Communication Support Element. The first one was when we were in Baghdad as part of task force Mercury back in the 2004, 2005 timeframe. And watching a couple Warrant Officers put in a Voice Over IP network. That was just unprecedented over a tactical Network. And it was their engineering ideas. They were the ones that took ATM, asynchronous transfer mode, switch capabilities that were inside the old legacy mobile subscriber equipment (MSE) and essentially created their own network. And this network ended up supporting over 10,000 Voice Over IP phones. I mean, you couldn't find an old MSE column except in a guard shack by the time the deployment was over. That was two Warrant Officers coming up with a way to actually take the equipment

they'd been handed, using it in a completely different way, dramatically increasing the Command-and-Control capabilities of the division, in contact. And that is the most important thing, adaptability and innovation in contact, operational effects...that is probably about the best example that I can come up.

I will tell you another one when I was in the JCSE. A young sailor was complaining to me about the kit that he had deployed with, and he had several changes that he would like to make to it. So, when we got back from the deployment, we put him in our engineering shop. We brought in several of the other Team Chiefs from across the element, Army, Air Force, Navy, and said "You don't like the kit, you design the next version that we're going to field across the element. And you're going to deploy with it." And they did. And that's what literally it's become, that kit designed by Soldiers, Sailors, Airmen and Marines. They were going to be Team Chiefs that deployed with that kit. Literally, it's the foundation of everything we're doing with the Army's expeditionary Signal Battalion enhanced today. Soldier ingenuity, I mean it just never ever ceases to amaze me.

Rick Piña: When you think of Signal, Cyber, EW. When you think about soldiers and civilians and contractors, and you go around and talk to these folks, what excites you about the people that we have in the force today? And then, what are you excited about as it relates to our future?

LTG Morrison: The people. Not the technology. The technology is going to come but it's going to be brought by people. It's going to be implemented by

people. So when I think about the future quite frankly, what gives me, great hope is our people.

It just never ceases to amaze me over these many, many years, how you can just watch folks, no matter how crummy the conditions, no matter how tough the environment, make a joke and figure something out that you never, ever, thought was going to be possible. Or come up with something that is going to make it better or fix a problem.

What gets me excited about the future? The people. If you're in the Signal or Cyber branch you should be pinching yourself. Because you are just going to be a key part of where our Army wants to head, and how our Army will fight in the future. That's pretty heady stuff. I would submit to you that it is a responsibility for everybody, whether a Soldier or a civilian, or one of our contractor teammates, that you need to be that key enabler and you need to think of what an operator needs, you need to know what maneuver commander's requirements are before they do. And you need to be as proactive as our predecessors. You need to do that in the future, maybe even more so. But it has never been about the technology, it's always been about the people taking a technology and making it work and making it be that critical enabler to support operations.

I am very, very hopeful for the future. I'm excited about it. That is my message. It's an exciting time of change in our Army, in the Signal Regiment, in the Cyber Branch. It's an important time and I am excited because of our people.



Toni Wilcox is an Army brat, veteran, and spouse who has written for the Military Times newspapers and Military Spouse magazine.

SCAMPI

by John R. Thomas, Army Colonel (Retired)

The US Special Operations Command was established in 1987 under Major Force Program 11 (MFP 11). The purpose was to consolidate all Special Operations Forces (SOF) under one command for funding,

training, acquisition, TTP and Command and Control Direct Action when directed.

Prior to this consolidation the communications systems of the three service SOF organizations and the Joint Special Operations Command (JSOC) were stovepiped and non-interoperable. They lacked the capacity to move critical data and imagery to SOF units when needed for planning, targeting and execution. Furthermore the acquisition and operations and maintenance were enormous. Of particular need was to provide quality imagery to JSOC. The legacy JSOC system relied on many point to point 56 KB circuits. Compounding the data movement deficiency was the lack of a common TS and TS(SCI) switched voice system to effect C2.

```
/app/mpiutil/scampi -h

Usage: scampi [-nh numhosts] [-pph procperhost] [-b MB] [-c[c]] [-l] [-m MB] [-p] [-t GB] [-v[v[v]]] [-y] \
--hostlist h1:h2[:h3:h4:...] [--nowrite] [--printonly] [-d keyname] [-e keyname] [-w] [--nooverwrite] \
[-h] [-s] source destination

MPI Flags
-nh N, Total number of hosts
-pph N, Number of mpi processes per host
--hostlist listpath, Path to a hostlist file which contains an ordered list of desired hosts

Optimization and Debugging Flags
-b MB, Transfers using MB MBytes blocksize)
-c, report cksum error/abort on cksum error
-l, use lustre create (with enhanced striping)
-m MB, MB-min file size for multithreaded r/w of file
-p, Preserve Permissions. Maintain the same file permissions after transfer
-t GB, Synchronizes ranks every GB GBytes transferred
-v, print debug messages (3 levels)
-y, Dynamic rank scheduling in large file transfers.
--nowrite, Perform transfer without writing data
--printonly, Print without performing actual transfer)

Encryption
--disable-enc, Disables encryption during transfers
-d keyfilename, Decrypt message, used to decrypt previously encryped files (-w)
-w, Write only the encrypted version of the transferred file

Other Flags
--exclude-hosts hosts, Will avoid using the passed comma separated list of hosts
--nooverwrite, Ignore files existing in destination
-h, print usage
```

Scalable Copy Accelerated by MPI (SCAMPI) is a command line utility to accelerate data transfer, and is currently installed on most HPCMP HPC systems.

One may think that the SCAMPI system was a darling of imagination, however, this would be misleading. A request from JSOC came into USSOCOM for additional funding for more 56 KB circuits to enhance their image distribution system. Back of the envelope calculations showed that for the price of three 56 KB circuits a full T1 circuit could be acquired. This provided a 24 to 1 increase in capacity over a single 56 KB circuit at one eighth to cost. Remember this was 1987 and the use of T1 was new to the DoD.

The finances were a no brainer. The challenge was how to maximize the bandwidth for other critical services, e.g. unclassified voice, TS voice and TS(SCI) voice Fax and etc. (This was before the Internet TCP/IP and WWW technology were widespread). To solve this the SCAMPI architecture was designed to “tunnel” through a TS (SCI) high system using super encrypted channels on the T1 to separate the unclassified voice and TS Red Switch trunks. This was a novel approach to say the least.

SCAMPI originally started as a hub and spoke network but quickly evolved to a highly survivable

mesh. In 1990 deployable SCAMPI nodes were implemented. Soon after TCP/IP and web based applications became available.

The success of SCAMPI brought attention from other elements of the DoD and especially DISA. Although the TS(SCI) system high architecture was not copied it did provide the primary impetus for the Defense Information Systems Network (DISN). DISA later unsuccessfully tried to roll SCAMPI into the DISN. Eventual integration and cooperation ensued.

The rapid implementation of SCAMPI was the product of the general SOF approach to meeting any mission. Streamlined acquisition, bottom up requirement development and agility were prime factors. Decision authority was pushed down to appropriate levels. Funding decisions were quick. Implementation and operations teams were small.



Army Colonel (Ret.) John R. Thomas (left) and his nephew, newly commissioned 2nd Lt. Joey Zirkel at West Point, New York.

"NO ORDINARY SIGNAL UNIT"

The 112th Signal Battalion in Panama

by Christopher E. Howard

Bullets ripped through Hangar 450 at Albrook Air Station, Panama, in the late evening of 19 December 1989, just as U.S. Army Special Forces Major (MAJ) Kevin M. Higgins and his Company A, 3rd Battalion, 7th Special Forces Group (A/3-7th SFG) prepared to depart for their H-Hour target: the Pacora River Bridge. "We lifted off to go to the fight," Higgins explained, "but the fight had come to the men at the hangar." Two of them were Staff Sergeant (SSG) Henry N. McCrae and Sergeant (SGT) Steven I. Elizalde, from the 112th Signal Battalion (Airborne), one of the newest Army Special Operations Forces (ARSOF) units. Their small signal element, consisting of two, three-man Special Operations Communications Assemblage (SOCA) teams, was providing secure communications for the Special Operations Command, South (SOC SOUTH), led by Colonel (COL) Robert C. 'Jake' Jacobelly.

Later, while he scanned his target from a cow pasture on the west side of the Pacora River, MAJ Higgins talked with Lieutenant Colonel (LTC) David J. Wilderman (J-3, SOC SOUTH) and Captain (CPT) Charles T. Cleveland (S-3, 3-7th SFG) "like they were standing next to me." The SOCA team at Albrook provided Wilderman and Cleveland the situational awareness to prioritize high-demand assets, like the AC-130 Spectre gunship and the quick reaction force (QRF) at Albrook. Once committed, SOC SOUTH had nothing to reinforce other elements in contact. Clear and timely communications were essential to mission success on the opening night of Operation JUST CAUSE, and the 112th Signal Battalion SOCAs delivered. They continued to do so throughout the operation.

This article details 112th Signal Battalion origins and explains how it was manned and equipped as a dedicated special operations communications battalion. The battalion's 'trial-by-fire' in Panama, 1989 – 1990 is highlighted. The focus is the SOCA teams that provided SOC SOUTH and ARSOF elements secure tactical communications during Operation JUST CAUSE and the follow-on stability operation, PROMOTE LIBERTY.

Origins



From its activation in 1986 until 1990, 112th Signal Battalion soldiers wore the Shoulder Sleeve Insignia (SSI) of 1st Special Operations Command, its higher headquarters.

The Army committed to modernizing its special operations forces (SOF) after the hostage rescue mission in Iran (Operation EAGLE CLAW) failed in 1980. 1st Special Operations Command (1st SOCOM) was provisionally established at Fort Bragg, North Carolina, in 1982, to command and control ARSOF. About the same time, forward-thinking officers began 'beating the drum' for a signal unit capable of supporting both 1st SOCOM and theater-level Joint Unconventional Warfare Task Forces (JUWTF).

One such officer was MAJ James D. 'Dave' Bryan, a Special Forces (SF) and Ranger-qualified Signal Officer. His experience in 7th SFG (including two years commanding its signal company

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Q&A with BG Jeth Rey *cont. from page 6*

lessons I have learned throughout the different Special Operations units to which I have been assigned have molded me. Within Special Operations, I've been assigned to Psychological Operations, 112th Signal Battalion, 75th Ranger

Regiment, and a Special Mission Unit. I had the honor of being assigned to support at the Executive level at White House Communication Agency and then at my previous assignment was CENTCOM. All these assignments have really prepared me for my current assignment as the Director of the Network Cross Functional Team in which we are shaping the vision of the Army's tactical network.

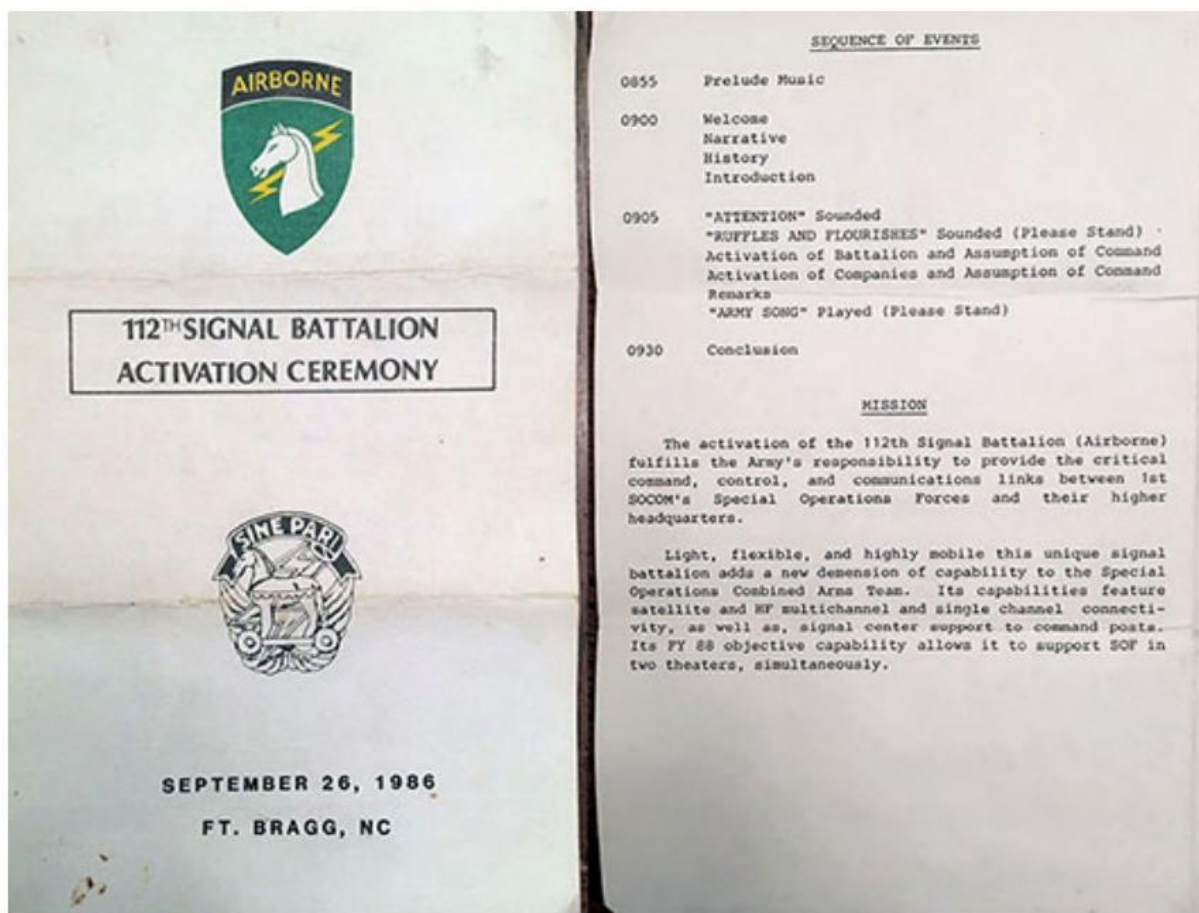
In summary, serving within the Special Operations Community, going from junior enlisted, to NCO, to Warrant, to commissioned Officer within the Special Operations community has molded me into the General Officer I am. If a soldier approached me who is eager to get ahead, learn and advance, one of the things I would recommend is that the soldier look towards opportunities to assess for and potentially serve in Special Operations. Spec Ops has an environment that provides the latest technical advances in communications and will really lay the foundation going forward both as a capable, mature Soldier.



A highly respected Special Operations communicator and Cyber leader, Rey started out in 1983 as a private in Korea, but soon advanced through the enlisted ranks to become a non-commissioned officer (NCO) in the 112th Signal Battalion (SO) (see accompanying article) and a Senior NCO in the Ranger Regiment as a Sergeant First Class. He volunteered for Warrant Officer school to expand his technical skills

which he again used in the Ranger Regiment upon his graduation. Following the advice of LTG (Ret.) Frank Kearney, his Ranger battalion commander, Rey then went to Officer Candidate School where he was commissioned as a 2LT in his first step toward his current status as a Signal Flag Officer. In a testimony to BG Rey's abilities, LTC Kearney brought 2LT Rey back to the Ranger Battalion to fill the Signal Officer position prior to Rey even attending his officer basic course. Once Rey had the Basic Course under his belt, he spent the next seventeen years providing critical communications support to senior commanders and special operators. These included the SOUTHCOM Commander, Green Berets and Special Operations Aviators, Tier One operators in our most sensitive Special Mission Units, and the President. As Rey transitioned to the most senior ranks, he continued to support Cyber operations around the globe. First as the Commander of the 516th Signal Brigade in the Pacific and then as the J6 for the United States Central Command (CENTCOM) in Tampa, FL. BG Jeth Rey is not finished as he recently assumed a new role as the Director, Network Cross-Functional Team where he will influence communications capability and doctrine for years to come.





The 112th Signal Battalion activation ceremony program from 26 September 1986 became a keepsake for William D. Childs, one of its charter members. *(Photo Courtesy of William D. Childs)*

[1977 – 1979]) made him aware of the challenges inherent to joint special operations communications. When Bryan returned to Fort Bragg in June 1984 as the Assistant Chief of Staff/Communications and Electronics Officer, 1st SOCOM, he championed the creation of an ARSOF signal unit capable of supporting ARSOF headquarters and task forces in multiple theaters. At the time, neither the Joint Communications Support Element (JCSE), the only joint SOF signal unit, nor the SF signal companies, were resourced for those missions. The 112th Signal Battalion (Special Operations) (Airborne) was established provisionally in June 1986, with Bryan in command, and was formally activated at Fort Bragg on 17

September 1986. It inherited the lineage of the World War II-era 512th Airborne Signal Company and the 112th Airborne Army Signal Battalion, both inactive since 1945. It had an authorized strength of 16 officers and 229 enlisted soldiers, organized into a Headquarters Detachment, a Base Operations Company and a Forward Communications Support Company. Manning came from excess Signal Corps billets rather than from within 1st SOCOM. Its soldiers quickly identified themselves as ‘Shadow Warriors,’ derived from the unit motto *Penetra Le Tenebre* – Penetrate the Shadows.

Per the TO&E, the 112th Signal Battalion was to “provide required C₃ [command, control, and

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Bringing SOF Communications to the Fight

By Brett Patron

As all Signaliers know, it is hard to run a war without communications, but that is exactly the situation the United States European Command (EUCOM) Theater Special Operations Command (TSOC) found itself in in the 1980s. Special Operations Command Europe (SOCEUR) was knee deep in the Cold War without the communications support needed to wage the fight on both the European and African continents. Special Operations Forces (SOF) are generally managed in peacetime by the United States Special Operations Command (USSOCOM) through their Service Components and then allocated in wartime to geographic combatant commands (COCOM) (CCMD) like the United States Central Command (USCENTCOM) or USEUCOM where they are under the command of the regional TSOC. The peacetime to wartime concept briefs well, but the reality is SOF elements are often engaged in pre-crisis activities like foreign internal defense (FID), building partner capacity (BPC), or other SOF missions well before a wartime situation is formally recognized.

While SOCEUR had a fully staffed J6 directorate for planning and coordination, it lacked an execution arm for signal operations. That all changed on 1 November 1985, with the formation of the SOCEUR Signal



Detachment (Airborne). Based on a USEUCOM Command directive (1), this first incarnation was a 22 Soldier unit assigned the 52d Signal Battalion. An additional 20 Soldiers, augmentees from across US Army Europe, were to be provided on request. This construct soon proved unworkable because of the short notice, 24/7 alert cycle. As a result, in October of 1986 the Commander of US Army Europe directed a change, configuring the SOCEUR Signal Detachment (SSD) with a Commander and 41 enlisted personnel. (2) The first commander of the SOCEUR Signal Detachment (Airborne) was Captain Tederyl (Ted) R. Stallworth and First Sergeant Jim Thompson was the SSD's initial top NCO. It adopted the motto "Never Fail". While not realized at the time, the SOCEUR Signal Detachment was the precursor to what would become the model for all TSOCs.

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Bringing SOF Communications to the Fight

Based at Patch Barracks, Stuttgart (Vaihingen), Germany, the SSD's mission was to "provide initial wartime communications support to Commander, SOCEUR (COMSOCEUR) and US Special Operations liaison elements at various NATO HQ." Additionally, SSD was tasked to "provide C2 communications support to COMSOCEUR in support of contingency and special operations. A third task was to serve as the personal communications support for the Deputy Commander, US European Command. (3)

Almost immediately, SSD was tested in real-world missions. Their first operational mission supported the 1986 Operation ELDORADO CANYON (the US response to Libya based terrorist attacks including a Berlin nightclub bombing). Other early missions included support to hostage rescue operations (1986 to 1991), Operation STEEL BOX (removal of chemical weapons from Europe), and deployments to Turkey for Operations DESERT STORM, and PROVIDE COMFORT, both in 1991. In this latter mission, SSD earned the Joint Meritorious Unit Award. (4)

This unique support was only possible because of the close coordination between SSD and the SOCEUR J6 Directorate. While SSD provided the manpower and operators, the SOCEUR J6 spearheaded the innovation and secured the resources needed. Understanding the requirements of the SOCEUR deployable HQs is where SOCEUR J6 developed the ideas and systems that SSD would train to proficiently operate. These requirements served to fuel creative application of technology, training methods, and deployment techniques key to both their past successes and opportunities for the future.

Going into the 1990s, SSD often deployed, focused on three types of missions: rapid deployment to the continent of Africa for a variety of non-combatant



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Bringing SOF Communications to the Fight

evacuation operations (NEO), humanitarian assistance, and low-intensity combat/counterterrorism. Several of these missions required small teams to launch on short notice as part of the European Survey and Assessment Team (ESAT) providing initial connectivity between USEUCOM and the crisis area. Additionally, when required, a larger contingent of the Detachment deployed to provide C2 communications for HQ SOCEUR when it formed a Joint Special Operations Task Force (JSOTF).

Example NEO missions include Operations SILVER ANVIL (following the 1992 coup in Sierra Leone); ASSURED RESPONSE (Liberian Civil War, 1996); GUARDIAN RETRIEVAL/FIRM RESPONSE (Evacuation of US Citizens from the former Zaire, during the First Congo War, 1997). Humanitarian assistance missions included Operations PROVIDE HOPE (Aid to former Soviet Republics, 1992); CT-43a Recovery (Aircraft Crash, Croatia 1996) and Operation ATLAS RESPONSE (Mozambique flood relief, 2000). SSD was also part of the various peace keeping and stabilization efforts in Bosnia-Herzegovina beginning in 1996 (Operations JOINT FORGE, JOINT GUARDIAN, ALLIED FORCE, FERVENT ARCHER).

In 1997, then Lt Colonel William "Bronco" Lane published a paper as part of his Naval War College studies, considering the tenets for successful communications supporting special operations. (5) He previously commanded the 112th Special Operations Signal Battalion (Airborne) at Fort Bragg. Within this unit were several 15-Soldier Signal Detachments, including one earmarked for Germany. Part of his thesis was that the mission for SOCEUR support should belong to the 112th, and that such support represented

"mission creep" for the mission of SSD's current parent, 52d Signal Battalion.

The paper touched off a series of discussions and analyses to determine the best way to provide communications support to SOCEUR, and all the various Theater Special Operations commands. He suggested that the 42-Soldier SOCEUR detachment was not sustainable in each Theater, while the smaller 15-Soldier variant limited operational flexibility.

In May of 2000, US Special Operations Command and the US Army agreed to re-form the SOCEUR Signal Detachment as a 32-Soldier unit, assigned to 112th Special Operations Signal Battalion. In so doing, the 15-Soldier "Germany" detachment merged with 17 spaces from the existing 52d Signal Battalion SSD. The goal was to complete the transfer and reorganization by 30 September 2002.



On 2 April 2002, Captain Brett Patron and First Sergeant Allan Fairley cased the guidon of SOCEUR Signal Detachment (Airborne), 52d Signal Battalion, presenting it to Lt Colonel Cyrus Gywn. They then received the new guidon of Signal Detachment (Europe), 112th Special Operations Signal Battalion (Airborne) from Lt Colonel Robert Bell. In attendance at the ceremony on Patch Barracks was Colonel "Bronco" Lane, commanding 2d Signal Brigade, the 52d Signal Battalion's higher headquarters.

From the start, circumstances tested the new 112th-assigned Detachment as SSD maintained a presence supporting JSOTF-Sarajevo, deployed a team to the Republic of Georgia, and began support rotations for

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Bringing SOF Communications to the Fight

the emerging Operation ENDURING FREEDOM. SSD's first major operation in Africa was 2002's Cote D'Ivoire NEO, AUTUM RETURN, followed immediately by two more NEOs, SHEPHERD SENTRY (Central African Republic, 2002) and SHINING EXPRESS (Liberia, 2003).

From its early days in the 52d Signal Battalion, SSD's reputation for rapid deployment and technology innovation became hallmarks. The unit was outfitted with the available conventional signal capabilities of the time - HF radio, teletype systems, and the earliest UHF Tactical Satellite radio systems. These systems were not designed for small team, rapid deployment. With the support and assistance of the SOCEUR J6, the Detachment rapidly adapted their equipment to be modular, more "man-portable," and rapidly transportable on a variety of military and dual-use aircraft. As satellite terminals evolved and the internet became a C2 platform, so too has SSD's ability to find new ways to accomplish its missions in challenging circumstances and austere locations. Ideas born in SSD and SOCEUR J6 have found their way into communications units across the SOF community and

into the US Army. Its alumni have served in a variety of specialized and high-visibility communications units across the Department of Defense.

In 2012 when Admiral McRaven (as the USSOCOM Commander) decided to standardize the structure of the TSOCs, the SOCEUR Signal Detachment's proven organization served as the model for the other Theater SOC Signal Detachments. Of the seven current TSOC detachments - all now assigned to the 112th Signal Battalion - five follow the 32-Soldier SSD model and the other two are a smaller 15-Soldier variant.

SSD continues to provide innovative, ready, and reliable communications teams, supporting various mission profiles. It has been on jump-status continuously since its initial formation in 1985, and this paratrooper spirit motivates its innovative and can-do mindset.



Footnotes:

(1) Message: USCINCEUR, ECDC, 061505 Feb 84; Message: USCINCEUR, ECDC, 280807Z Jul 84

(2) Memorandum, CINCUSAREUR, AEAIM-PA-PE, 181600Z Mar 85

(3) Boison, Matt, "Operation PROVIDE COMFORT, A Communications Perspective", June 1992. (HQ USEUCOM), pg 127

(4) Authorized Joint Meritorious Unit Awards (as of Sep 2020). (2021). Retrieved 27 June 2021, from <https://prhome.defense.gov/Portals/52/Documents/Approved%20JMUAAs%20-%202020%2009%2030.pdf>

(5) Lane, W. (1997). JSOTF Communications; Tenets for Successful Operational Communications in Operations Other Than War. Naval War College

communications] systems between the unified commander, major SOF headquarters, Army Special Operations Command [1st SOCOM] subordinate commands, and other commands as required/directed." The battalion was to support SOCSOUTH and Special Operations Command, Europe (SOCEUR), which belonged to Army-supported combatant commands (COCOMs): U.S. Southern Command (USSOUTHCOM) and U.S. European Command (USEUCOM). The battalion was also "to establish communications liaison teams at various levels within the host country and/or supported and adjacent commands." Those teams became synonymous with the equipment they used: the "Special Operations Liaison Communications Assemblage" (SOLCA), later simplified "SOCA." The battalion's fourteen SOCA teams were initially assigned to Company B, but a subsequent reorganization reallocated them evenly between two regionally aligned companies.

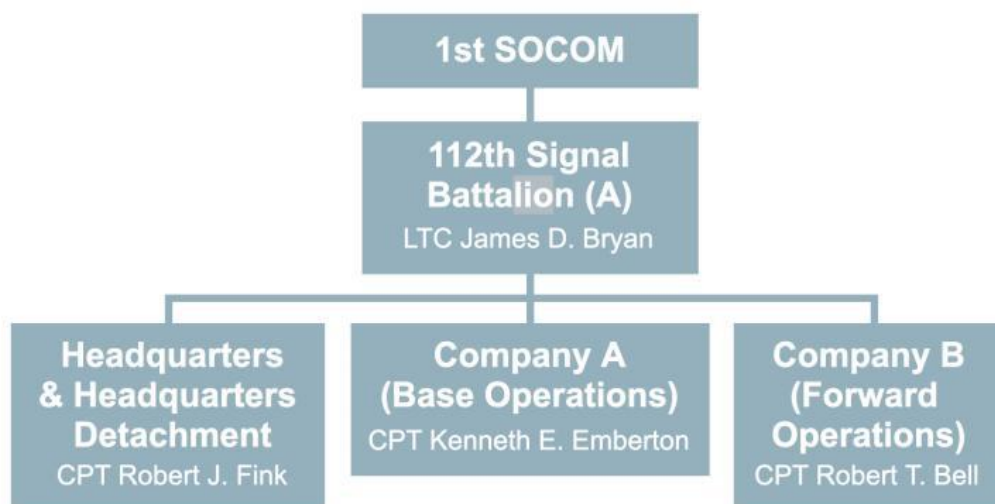
Each SOCA team consisted of three soldiers: one Sergeant First Class (SFC/E-7), one Sergeant (SGT/E-5), and one Specialist (SPC/E-4), although it was not

uncommon for Staff Sergeants (SSG/E-6) to serve as team leaders or for Privates First Class (PFC/E-3) to serve on SOCAs. Each team member was Military Occupational Specialty (MOS) 31C, Radio Operator-Maintainer or, less commonly, another 31-series MOS. Airborne-qualified and able to deploy on the first aircraft, SOCAs provided secure communications between the theater-level SOF commander and subordinate elements.

As the first 112th Signal Battalion Commander ('Shadow Six'), LTC Bryan oversaw a period of rapid growth for the new battalion. It doubled in size, from 144 soldiers at activation to its full complement of 288 by mid-1988. Bryan prioritized getting the right people, fostering the right attitude, and providing them with the right equipment for the job. In this, he was aided by Command Sergeant Major (CSM) Billie F. Phipps, a capable battalion staff, and highly competent non-commissioned officers (NCOs). His command philosophy was condensed into five words: "Excellence in everything we do."

112th Signal Battalion Organization and Leadership

September 1986



The 112th Signal Battalion Distinctive Unit Insignia (DUI) was approved on 15 August 1986.

Orange and white

(silver) are the colors of the Signal Corps. The dagger, an established symbol of Special Operations organizations is black and white (silver) in reference to the Battalion's covert and overt missions. It is winged to emphasize present day capabilities for speed of deployment by air. The black color enhances the motto which is translated "Penetrate the Shadows." The lightning flashes reflect electronic technology. The motto is in Italian in reference to the unit's first area of combat operations.

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112th Signal Battalion soldiers pose outside their temporary battalion headquarters near Gruber Road on Fort Bragg, North Carolina, circa fall 1986. The battalion relocated across post early the following year. *(Photo Courtesy of William D. Childs)*

From the beginning, battalion leaders promoted a competitive mindset. The soldiers responded, believing that theirs was a special unit, due to its unique ARSOF support mission. Team sports and battalion runs built unit cohesion. Physical training was tough. Expectations were high, initiative was rewarded, and leaders were held accountable. Unit morale surged as a result. “They knew it was not ‘business as usual,’” Bryan recalled.

Armed with Army studies and requirements documents, such as the Army Mission Area Analysis (1983), Special Operations Forces Master Plan (1984), and the Multi-command Required Operational Capability 2-84 (1984), Bryan prepared to brief his plan to the Army. He recognized that the Signal Corps would be reluctant to support the creation of a dedicated “ARSOF Communications Support Element,” which borrowed from Joint terminology; a signal battalion similar to those in the ‘Big Army’ would be an easier sell. Bryan identified three specific

needs for an ARSOF communications battalion: a flexible structure that allowed SOF communications packages to be tailored to the supported mission; a modernization strategy that ensured ARSOF communicators had state-of-the-art equipment, through priority placement on the Department of the Army Master Priority List; and a “professional home for ARSOF communicators” that grounded them for continuity and did not stunt their career progression. His pitch succeeded, and the Army approved Table of Organization and Equipment (TO&E) 11015J500, “Special Operations Communications Battalion,” on 1 April 1985.

Bryan also understood that most conventional Army communications systems were too bulky for ARSOF’s short notice, small footprint deployments. To get the right equipment, the battalion customized standard Army signal systems to meet mission requirements

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and procured cutting-edge commercial systems when necessary. It also fielded new super high frequency (SHF) satellite communications and high frequency (HF) multichannel systems. Special fabrication was done 'in house,' often with assistance from Tobyhanna Army Depot, Pennsylvania. Two such projects had major impacts.

The first was the SOCA kit, consisting of ultra-high frequency (UHF) tactical satellite (TACSAT), HF, and frequency modulation (FM) line-of-sight (LOS) radios; secure facsimile and teletype; encryption devices (KY-84, KY-57, KYV-5 or Sunburst processor); commercial power interface; and a generator. In its original configuration, the kit weighed over 1,200 pounds and was transported in a coffin-sized container. Battalion personnel cut the bulky metal racks that held the various systems to a more manageable size, and reorganized the other SOCA components until the entire kit fit in four footlocker-sized containers that could be carried by two soldiers and transported on a commercial aircraft. This was important because aircraft space dictated number of personnel and equipment size. The SOCA was often the only 112th communications package deployed on ARSOF missions.

A second customization project was installing a dual rear axle on the standard five-

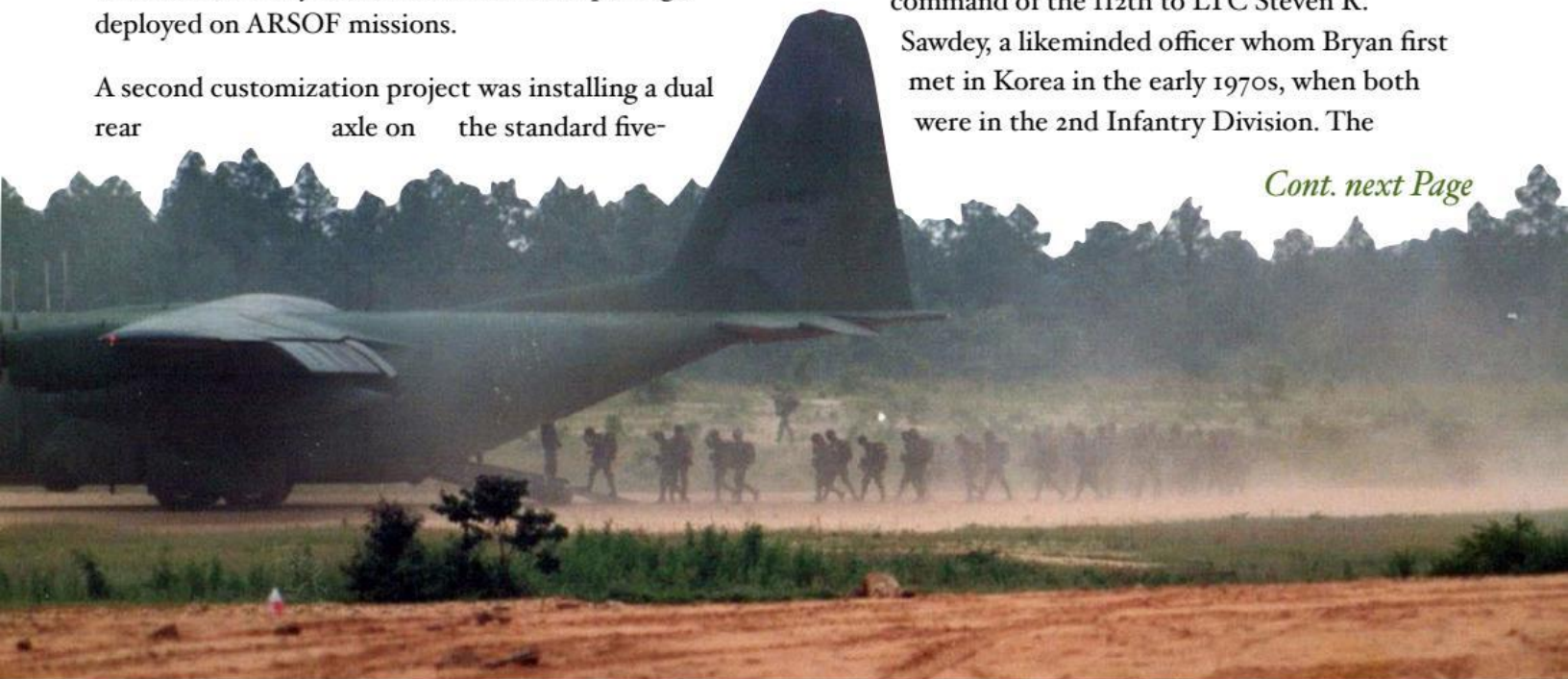
quarter ton M-1028 Commercial Utility Cargo Vehicle (CUCV), making it capable of hauling an AN/TSC-93A multichannel satellite terminal previously transported by an M35 two-and-a-half ton truck. The eight-foot parabolic antenna, previously carried on a second truck, was modified to fit on a trailer attached to the custom CUCV. The entire system could roll on/off a C-130 or C-141 aircraft, something not possible in its original configuration, but essential for SOF

employment. In June 1988, LTC Bryan handed over command of the 112th to LTC Steven R. Sawdey, a likeminded officer whom Bryan first met in Korea in the early 1970s, when both were in the 2nd Infantry Division. The



Major General (Ret.) James David Bryan was instrumental in winning Army approval for what became the 112th Signal Battalion. He then served as its first Commander, the first to hold the title "Shadow Six." In 2019, he was named an **Army Special Operations Forces Icon**.

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Soldiers from Company A, 112th Signal Battalion conduct an engine running operation (i.e. 'hot load') onto a waiting C-130 Hercules aircraft in preparation for an airborne operation at Sicily Drop Zone, Fort Bragg, North Carolina in March 1990. The Airborne requirement helped build *esprit de corps* and promoted an elite mindset among 112th soldiers. (Photo courtesy of James S. Kestner)

transition was nearly seamless, as Sawdey shared his predecessor's commitment to technological innovation and realistic, mission-focused training. To him, getting the "right people" included airborne-qualified soldiers, and he fought to keep this requirement when manning shortfalls led the Army to send non-airborne personnel to the 112th. He also believed the best way to gain acceptance in the SOF community was to "get out there and do stuff." Sawdey's command philosophy reflected an aggressive mentality, and included an addenda: "Be prepared to kill for the mission." CPT James S. 'Steve' Kestner, one of his company commanders, made sure that every one of his soldiers read it: "We were not your conventional signal unit."

The combination of tough training and high morale had LTC Sawdey's 'Shadow Warriors' eager to deploy and prove themselves. Many of the battalion leaders, Kestner noted, were SF-qualified 'long-tabbers' or had previously served in Special Operations units, including its first two commanders. Senior NCOs were highly trusted, having been proven under stress. Experience had been gained in exercises like *FUERZAS UNIDAS* in USSOUTHCOM, and *FLINTLOCK* in USEUCOM. These exercises allowed the battalion to practice supporting a JSOTF, while identifying organizational and individual strengths and weaknesses.

Panama SOCAs gained operational experience in deployments to USSOUTHCOM, beginning with the HAT TRICK counterdrug missions in 1987. After COL Charles H. 'Chuck' Fry, the SOCSOUTH commander, requested SOCA support in early 1988, teams began 60 to 90-day rotations to Panama, Honduras, El Salvador, and Colombia, often with only a two week break between trips. The operational tempo (OPTEMPO) was grueling, but it became a point-of-pride for the SOCA men. Team leader SSG Thomas A. Ayers, a charter member of the battalion, recalls being gone so much during the late 1980s that his landlord prorated his rent, and joked that he needed a Green Card to get back into the country.

The 112th's SOCSOUTH mission took on greater importance as ARSOF intensified contingency planning

for combat operations (BLUE SPOON) in Panama. MAJ Donald Kropp, battalion Operations Officer (S-3), represented the 112th Signal Battalion in those sessions, with First Lieutenant Oliver K. Wyrski. Due to the persistent U.S. presence in Panama, robust fixed station communications networks already existed in the Canal Zone, but they were susceptible to attack from the Panama Defense Forces (PDF), and under surveillance by at least three Soviet ships transiting the Canal. Furthermore, existing secure military networks were insufficient to accommodate the demand resulting from the large influx of forces in BLUE SPOON. Accordingly, MAJ Kropp planned for the battalion to supply the Joint SOF headquarters in Panama with its own satellite communications network, but knew that it would take time to move the equipment into place.

In early October 1989, with tensions between the U.S. and Panama escalating, two SOCA teams deployed as part of the security enhancement mission. Those teams, which included SSG McCrae and SGT Elizalde, were on the ground when Operation JUST CAUSE began on 20 December. However, the 112th did not receive the expected call to deploy more forces. As ARSOF units jumped into combat that night, and while 3-7th SFG carried out its D-Day missions, the majority of the 112th Signal Battalion was at Fort Bragg feeling "painfully invisible."

The omission was unintentional, a consequence of the short notice deployment, rapid pace of combat operations, and not being included early in the XVIII Airborne Corps-orchestrated deployment list. MAJ Kropp had planned a greater part for the 112th, but those factors reduced the battalion role. As a result, 'Shadow Warrior' contributions to JUST CAUSE were largely tactical. It was "SOCA-led war for the 112th," said CPT Kestner. Regardless, LTC Sawdey sent him to Panama to "sort out what's going on" and to figure out how to get more of the battalion into the fight.

On 20 December, CPT Kestner and SFC Robert Malton flew to Panama, arriving at Howard Air Force Base. The two were taken by a 3-7th SFG security element to SOCSOUTH headquarters at Albrook Air Station.

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To make its AN/TSC-93A satellite terminal transportable on a C-130 aircraft, the 112th Signal Battalion worked with the 528th Special Operations Support Battalion and Tobyhanna Army Depot to modify a standard M-1028 Commercial Utility Cargo Vehicle, seen here, with dual-wheel rear axle. The project was completed in June 1988, and field-tested during the FLINTLOCK exercise of U.S. European Command.

There, Kestner briefed COL Jacobelly, who praised the two SOCAs in country. He told Kestner to help the SOCSOUTH J-3 and J-6 'plus up' signal support by writing a Statement of Requirements to justify more SOCAs. Kestner worked with MAJ Roberto A. Ortiz, the J-6, and CPT Charles Cleveland, the S-3, 3-7th SFG.

As CPT Kestner worked to get more SOCAs into Panama, Hangar 450 at Albrook came under fire a second time, most likely stray rounds from a gunfight near Quarry Heights. The SOCA radio operators noticed that the radio signal was suddenly much weaker. Quickly checking their equipment, they discovered that the tactical satellite antenna atop the hangar was rendered inoperable by gunfire. A backup system was activated, but it was a reminder that the fight was ongoing, despite major tactical successes in the opening days.

With the requirement for three additional SOCAs validated on 24 December 1989, the teams were notified. SSG Thomas Plunkett, SGT Darell A. Brown, and SPC Glenn G. Oliver made up one of those SOCAs. Like

many, SGT Brown had been to Central America multiple times since joining the 112th two years prior. This time, inclement weather at Fort Bragg presented an unexpected obstacle to him and the others

assembling for deployment. A neighbor with a four-wheel drive (4x4) vehicle delivered SGT Brown to his unit. LTC Sawdey sent out 4x4 trucks to gather others stranded by the snow. Once all of the teams were present, they departed as scheduled, reporting to SOCSOUTH Headquarters on Christmas Day.

Initially, the SOCAs in country were all located near Panama City, either at Albrook or Howard, but several 'pushed out' with supported ARSOF elements. SGT Brown's

SOCA team stayed at Albrook, providing a link between SOCSOUTH HQ and the teams at the remote forward operating bases (FOBs). SSG Thomas A. Ayers' SOCA team, by contrast, went to FOB 72 at Rio Hato airfield with Operational Detachment Bravo (ODB) 710, 2-7 SFG, who had relieved the Rangers. They kept information flowing between the Operational Detachments Alpha (ODAs) operating in the field and



SOCSOUTH SSI

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the ODB, and between the ODB and SOCSOUTH HQ.

On 30 December, two more SOCA teams were validated to support the *ad hoc* Civil Military Operations Task Force being established to support Operation PROMOTE LIBERTY stability operations. By the time these teams arrived on 1 January 1990, the PDF was largely neutralized and Panamanian dictator General Manuel Noriega was holed up in the *Nunciatura* in Panama City. Nonetheless, the lack of civil institutions and law enforcement presented problems.

When LTC Sawdey and his battalion command sergeant major (CSM) Louis 'Lou' Black got to Panama, he pushed to support all SF ODBs and ODAs operating throughout Panama with SOCAs. They provided critical TACSAT capabilities and secure, real-time communications to forward SF elements. The SOCA supporting ODB 770, A/3-7th SFG was SOCA

Team Four, made up of SFC Elijah C. Harvin's, SGT William D. Childs and SGT James Shepherd.

Headquartered at La Chorrera, Panama, SOCA Team Four sent critical information and intelligence to the battalion, and provided the ODB commander with printed operations orders, intelligence assessments, and updated rules of engagement from SOCSOUTH. These were passed to the ODAs further afield. "It was a fast moving situation," recalls Higgins. "The SOCA instinctively distinguished routine from critical message traffic, and alerted the commander accordingly." The SOCA Team Four mission with ODB 770 ended in mid-March 1990. Their two months of superb support did not go unnoticed.

The SOCSOUTH memorandum that awarded the Special Forces Shoulder Sleeve Insignia (SSI) as a combat patch for Operation JUST CAUSE participants included eighteen 112th Signal Battalion soldiers. When SOCA Team Four was inadvertently left off the list, MAJ Higgins formally requested his

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(L-R) Sergeant First Class (SFC) Robert Malton and Captain (CPT) James S. 'Steve' Kestner, Company A, 112th Signal Battalion, conduct sustained airborne training at 'Green Ramp,' Pope Air Force Base, North Carolina, December 1989. Their jump that day was ultimately cancelled due to U.S. Air Force repositioning of aircraft for the impending invasion of Panama (Operation JUST CAUSE). By 20 December 1989, the two men were on their way to Panama to 'plus up' 112th Signal Battalion signal support to SOCSOUTH. (Photo courtesy of James S. Kestner)



(L-R): Sergeant (SGT) William D. Childs, Staff Sergeant (SSG) Henry N. McCrae, and SGT Darell A. Brown pose in the SOCSOUTH radio room at Albrook Air Station in January 1990. All three were seasoned Special Operations Communications Assemblage (SOCA) operators, having multiple deployments to their credit. JUST CAUSE provided them their first combat deployment. (Photo Courtesy of William D. Childs)

three SOCA communicators be added. COL Jacobelly did so. "The 112th SOCA Team shared our hardships and dangers and manned the perimeter," Higgins explained. "That is why SFC Harvin's team earned the right to wear the SF shoulder patch."

Conclusion

The 112th Signal Battalion presence in Panama peaked at 30 personnel in early January 1990. It included seven SOCA teams, LTC Sawdey, CSM Black, and several staff planners. Some 112th soldiers redeployed back to Fort Bragg in January and, by the end of March 1990, only a small element, led by CPT Eric G. David, was supporting stability operations.

Although limited in numbers, the 'Shadow Warriors' in Panama 'punched above their weight,' providing SOCSOUTH and other ARSOF units secure communications when theater systems were overwhelmed. MAJ Kropp reported that, "in many cases, the 112th provided the only communications lifeline available to deployed Special Operations

elements" in Panama. LTC Sawdey described the performance of his veterans as "magnificent."

Some of those who spent Christmas 1989 in Panama would spend the next one in Saudi Arabia supporting Operation DESERT SHIELD. LTC Sawdey was not among them. He received orders for the Army War College, and handed over command to LTC Samuel R. Higdon in June 1990. Prior to leaving, Sawdey addressed his battalion. Noting the lack of fanfare for ARSOF returning from Panama, he told his soldiers, "It's in the nature of our character to be quiet professionals. Our identity is to be defined by what we accomplish, not who we are." Every soldier in the formation nodded. "At that moment," CPT Kestner "knew the 112th Signal Battalion was a brotherhood."



How SOF Got their Comms

by John Wilcox

I have known Major General (MG) Dave Bryan since 1985. We were both at a meeting in St Louis to discuss the soon to be fielded Improved High Frequency Radio System (IHFRS). He was there as the Assistant Chief of Staff, Communication-Electronics for the 1st Special Operations Command and I was there from E Co/51st Infantry Regiment as the first Long Range Surveillance Communications Platoon Leader since Vietnam. While

C4 capabilities for SOF and the Signal Regiment – it was his vision of the future that drove him to become Cyberman and establish a baseline for Army Cyber Operations that continues to this day. When I look at his nearly 35 years of military service, I see consistent themes of taking care of people and most importantly, leading by example.



Major General James David Bryan chats with Signal Soldiers.

Born and raised in Alabama, General Bryan graduated from Jacksonville State University in 1970 with a plan to teach high school chemistry, math, biology and his true love, literature. Fortunately, as an Army ROTC Scholarship recipient, he owed the Army four years of military service. He never left.

After a year of training where he was taught the basics of Army communications, became qualified as a Parachutist and Pathfinder, and earned his Ranger tab, Bryan was off to Fort Bragg to be the Battalion Signal Officer for 3/325th Airborne Infantry in the 82nd Airborne Division. As a Lieutenant he followed the advice of his father, a retired Master Sergeant, “Listen to your NCOs. Seek their opinion and trust them, but as an officer, always be their leader.” A year later he volunteered for Special Forces training earning his long tab and

Green Beret followed by assignment to a special mission unit at the JFK Center for Military Assistance. An overseas tour in Korea as the S-3 of the 122nd Signal Battalion checked an Army box before he returned to Ft. Bragg for assignment to the Support Battalion, 7th Special Forces Group as the S-4, then as the S-3, and finally as the Commander of the Signal Company. History is vague about whether he stayed in the battalion because was a good communicator or because he was the quarterback of their championship football team, but that notwithstanding, Bryan constantly worked above his pay grade to improve SOF communications.

IHFRS was the agenda item, it was clear Major (P) Bryan had bigger ideas - he was on a mission to persuade everyone at the conference and beyond that the Army needed to immediately modernize communications for Special Operations Forces (SOF) – from Special Forces to Training & Administration - all of it with the centerpiece being the creation of a Special Operations Signal Battalion that we know now as the 112th Signal Battalion (Special Operations) (Airborne). As I grew to know him, and work with him, I realized that the creation of the 112th might have been his first, but was not his last opportunity to create something new out of whole cloth. As he did with the 112th – applying his knowledge, experience, and passion for improving

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After the Advanced Course, Bryan again returned to the conventional Army with the 3rd Brigade, 1st Armored Division where he encountered a maintenance nightmare with radioteletype (RATT) systems. Leveraging his S-3 experience, Bryan got them fixed and kept them fixed, training the operators and maintenance soldiers with a “field SOP” that he wrote. Soon word spread and he was training other units with his field SOP until the entire armored task force had operational “RATT rigs.” This impressed the 7th Corps G-6 who had him reassigned to his staff just in time to



112th Signal Battalion (SO) activation - 1986

take over as the first S-3 of the 93rd Signal Brigade. As the first Corps level Signal Brigade, there was no doctrine so Bryan and his team again wrote a detailed Field SOP for Corps Area Signal Operations. Better than anything at Fort Gordon, the Signal Center slapped a cover on the SOP and began teaching it as doctrine. Inside that Signal Center cover, inside the 93rd Signal Brigade cover, at the bottom of the introduction was a signature, “Approved by: CPT James D. Bryan, Brigade S-2/3.”

After three years in Germany, Bryan was assigned to lead training for the US Army Recruiting Command under (then) MG Max Thurman. Thurman appreciated what he saw in Bryan’s complete overhaul of recruiter training and in fact, was the officer who promoted Bryan to Major. Bryan was the author of the Army College Fund program to give Army recruiters a leg up on the other military service recruiters and as an additional duty, Thurman added Bryan to the team that

developed the historic “Be All That You Can Be” campaign.

After attending Command and General Staff College, Bryan returned to Fort Bragg in 1984 as the ACofS, C-E of the new 1st Special Operations Command. Coinciding with his return was the drafting of multicombat required operational capability (MROC) 2-84 which was designed to modernize Special Operations Forces. Bryan and his staff inked thirty-six initiatives into MROC 2-84 including everything from rucksack satellite radios, multi-band radios, ruggedized laptops, rechargeable batteries, and yes, a special operations signal unit. Some wanted to call it a “squadron,” others a “communications support element” but Bryan successfully argued that it needed to be a Signal Battalion within the Signal Regiment with companies, platoons, and teams that would serve as the professional hub for special operations communications and communicators. When the Army Vice Chief of Staff (now, GEN Max Thurman) approved the activation of the SOF Signal Battalion, he knew that Bryan had been an early select to LTC and Battalion Command. As part of the approval, he reportedly said, “Activate this Battalion as soon as possible with Bryan in command. He created it, and he’ll get it done.” On September 17, 1986, the 112th Signal Battalion (Special Operations) (Airborne) was activated and LTC Bryan was its first commander, the first “Shadow 6” and in 2013 the 112th’s new compound at Fort Bragg was dedicated in his name.

After command with many operational lessons under his belt, Bryan attended the Army War College where he started looking at the next ridgeline and he wrote his award winning thesis on, “The Future of SOF Communications.” Given his ability to define requirements and drive needed change to include approval and activation of the 112th Signal Battalion (SO), some including myself, refer to Bryan as the “Father of Modern SOF Communications.”

As a LTC(P), Bryan was assigned to the Joint Staff J-6 in 1989 where he became the “go-to” guy during Desert Shield and Desert Storm. In a lessons learned report, he catalogued over 700 interoperability issues between generations of Army, sister service, and Coalition C4 systems which ultimately resulted in the Bryan led “C4I for the Warfighter” program that established the first-ever framework for platform-centric, network-centric and decision/knowledge-centric interoperability requirements and programs.

When Bryan assumed command of the 35th Airborne Signal Brigade in 1993, the unit had just completed fielding of the Army MSE systems. He knew that operational deployments were in their near future and that they had to be ready to participate in joint and coalition configurations. Over the next two years they deployed signal support seven times, each time providing first-ever MSE support to joint and coalition forces – in places like Somalia, Haiti, West and Central Africa, to name a few.

As Bryan was being selected for Brigadier General he started his transition from SOF Communicator to Cyber Operator. As the J-6 of the United States Pacific Command (USPACOM), Bryan realized that the Chief Information Officer (CIO) role was no longer a “Garrison” activity, but applied across the force so in 1998 he became the first Combatant Command CIO. Additionally, he recognized the requirement for coalition interoperability and established the Asia-Pacific Area Network (APAN) which is still in use today. He established the first-ever Theater C4 Coordination Center which was the predecessor of today’s Network Operations and Security Centers.

Selected for a second star, Bryan received a dual hat assignment in 2000 as the Vice Director, Defense Information Systems Agency (DISA) and as the Commander of Joint Task Force – Computer Network Defense. As Vice Director, he led the development of a first comprehensive doctrine for network operations and

security based on his experiences with the Theater C4 Coordination Center at USPACOM. As JTF Commander he led it through its evolution from JTF-CND to JTF-Computer Network Operations (JTF-CNO) and was the first Title 10 commander to have both the defensive and offensive cyber missions. The command eventually evolved to JTF-Global Network Operations (JTF-GNO). It was during his time as JTF commander that he created the character “Cyberman” and famously appeared in full costume at numerous conferences to bring much needed attention to the need to mainstream and professionalize cyber operations including establishing a cyber career field in the Army and other military services. In the Signal Regiment Museum, his “Cyberman” costume is on display and he is referred to as the “Father of Army Cyber.”

In 2003, Bryan had one last assignment. The Army Chief of Staff, GEN Schoomaker asked him to reorganize and re-equip the Signal Regiment to support the Army’s new modular Brigade concept. The Chief’s guidance was clear, “Give me a lot of the 112th” in terms of capabilities. Bryan formed and led a team, many members of which had worked for him over the years, and in four months they had a strategy that is still guiding the Regiment today.

Few officers leave a true lasting legacy, but in the case of MG Dave Bryan, he left two. The activation of the 112th Signal Battalion created a touchstone for Army SOF

communicators, and the formation of the JTF-CND laid the foundation for today’s CNO. Both were possible because Dave Bryan knew what right looked like and wouldn’t take no for an answer. Always a leader, he continues to be a friend and mentor to many.



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communications since the Vietnam War. Chief Ziesman was a plank holder in SFOD-Delta and literally deployed to every crisis operation from Eagle Claw to Desert Storm. While today we take satellite communications for granted that wasn't the case in 1979. Needing reliable beyond line of site capability for the Eagle Claw Hostage Rescue mission, Mr.

Zeisman and his Operations Sergeant modified existing radios to operate over the Air Force's Tactical SATCOM system thereby serving as a prototype for the manpack SATCOM radios we have today. Moving forward, Mr. Ziesman was the principle SFOD-Delta communications planner for Urgent Fury, Just Cause, and then Desert Shield/Desert Storm, each

time deploying forward to serve as a primary communicator for the operation. Retiring from active duty in 1991, Mr. Zeisman returned to SFOD-Delta as a government civilian putting his years of experience to work developing the next generation HF and SATCOM radios for Special Missions Units. His work in developing and codifying tactics, techniques, and procedures (TTPs) proved critical during operations in Somalia and Bosnia. In 1998, he moved to the Joint Special Operations Command (JSOC) J6 as the Deputy Director of Command, Control, Communications, Computers, and Intelligence (C4I) where he continued to influence SOF C4 policy and doctrine. His work laid the foundation for the tactical and operational SOF networks we see today and as such, Mr. Ziesman is considered by many to the Godfather of SOF Communications. If Mr. Ziesman is the Godfather, then Mr. Pelaez is the Crusty Uncle. Master Sergeant Mike Pelaez enlisted as Airborne Radio Operator and immediately volunteered for the Special Forces Qualification Course from which he graduated in 1968. With the



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John A Wilcox is a former member of the Senior Executive Service (SES) and Retired Army Colonel who spent 36 years with the Department of Defense including 23 years in the Special Operations Community.



Brigadier General William J. Kennedy, USA (Ret.)

It is with deep regret that we inform you of the death of Brigadier General William J. Kennedy, USA, Retired, who passed away on 16 October 2020 at the age of 94. Brigadier General Kennedy retired in 1979 after over 28 years of service. During the latter part of his career he served as Assistant Commandant, United States Army Signal School, Fort Gordon, Georgia and later as Deputy Controller, Central Operating Authority, Supreme Headquarters Allied Powers, Europe.

Tom Hoyle, Lt. Col. (Ret.)

The passing of the 34th recipient of the Bronze Order of Mercury. LTC (Ret.) Tom Hoyle was laid to rest Yesterday at the



Massachusetts National cemetery at Joint Base Cape Cod. Of note, as we as a regiment prepare for the next iteration of Technet Augusta, then MAJ Tom Hoyle was the original project officer for the first

Signal Symposium way back when it first started. As the first company commander for the newly relocated Signal Student Officer Company when it first stood up at Fort Gordon, he set the standard for generations of signal personnel. A Vietnam veteran of two tours, he finished his last duty assignment in Signal Towers at the TCM Multifunctional Computers setting the stage for what is now USCYBERCOM. Thanks LTC (Ret.) Thomas L. Hoyle for your untiring duty to God, Country, and Family. Dad...As we say in the US Army Signal Corps: "Meet you on the high Ground!!!" **RIP...as** the third Generation of The Hoyle Clan are carrying on the military Tradition in both the Navy and Army.



Honoring Special Operations Communicators

by John Wilcox

Cont. from Page 3

exception of his initial training, Master Sergeant Pelaez, and then Mr. Pelaez, served his entire career of 43 years in the Special Operations community or in support of SOF. With his first assignment to 1st

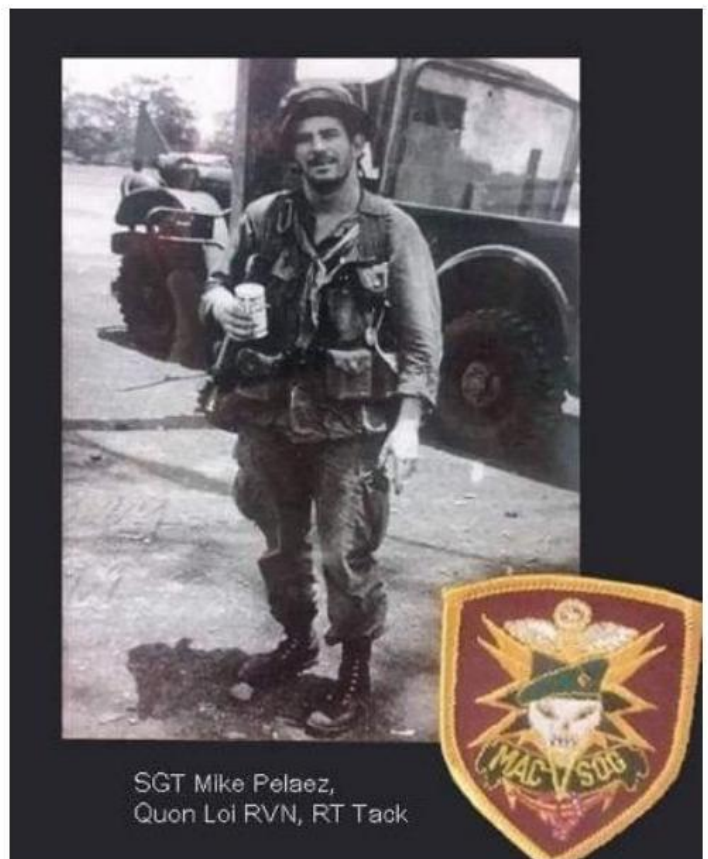


CW4 Zeisman prior to Eagle Claw insertion into Iran.

Special Forces Group Alpha (SFG) (A) in Okinawa, it wasn't long before Master Sergeant Pelaez volunteered for duty in Vietnam with the Military Assistance Command, Vietnam – Studies and Observations Group (MACV-SOG). Lots of myths abound about MACV-SOG, but two statistics tell the story. Thirteen members of MACV-SOG earned

the Medal of Honor and literally 99% of unit members were wounded or killed. Fortunately, Master Sergeant Pelaez was only one of the wounded earning his Purple Heart in 1969 while providing covering fire to allow his Team to break contact. He recovered and then returned to Vietnam and MACV-SOG to teach in the Reconnaissance Team Leaders Course and then serve as an adviser to a Cambodian Battalion before returning to the United States. After serving with 7th SFG(A) in Panama, Master Sergeant Pelaez again volunteered, this time for JSOC where he was the first Plank Owner for the newly established Joint Communications Unit (JCU). With JCU he continued to support real world operations including deploying with SFOD-Delta for the BG Dozier rescue in Italy and culminating with a parachute jump into Grenada as part of Urgent Fury. After service as a First Sergeant at the Joint Communications Support Element (JCSE) and attendance at the Sergeant's Major Academy, Master Sergeant Pelaez retired from active duty in

1989. Similar to Mr. Zeisman, after retiring from uniform, Master Sergeant Pelaez became a government civilian at USSOCOM continuing to support the Special Operations Force, starting out with C4 requirements and culminating as the J6 Deputy for Operations where he was the absolute continuity as USSOCOM reorganized for the 21st century. As the Crusty Uncle, Mike Pelaez provided mentorship and guidance across the Force and to numerous J6s and CIOs. The Special Operations community treats communications as the mission critical task that it is and develops communicators to meet that task. Mr. Zeisman and Mr. Pelaez are two of many who have risen to the challenge and been Special Operations Communicators.



SGT Mike Pelaez,
Quon Loi RVN, RT Tack



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The Board of Directors has voted to pursue this facility as the the future site for the now closed U.S. Army Signal Museum. Located next to Gate One at Fort Gordon, this facility was originally built to host the National Science Center. This facility and the adjacent grounds provide a great opportunity for FGHMS to share our legacies, stories, and to inspire the future generation. **Will you join us to raise the money to secure this facility?**

<https://gordonhistoricalmuseum.org/donate/>



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◀ FGHMS Special Advisor Bob Gilbert as BG Albert J. Myer at AFCEA TechNet Augusta



FGHMS Executive Director Amy Tuschen receiving a \$2,500 contribution from the Augusta Fort Gordon AFCEA Chapter.



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